

The Glass Clocks of Veridia

An original tale written exclusively for a Retrieval-Augmented Generation demonstration. None of the people, places, or events below exist anywhere outside this document.

1. The Town That Counted Backwards

In the lowland province of Veridia, between the salt marshes of Quennar and the iron hills of Tolbrach, stood the small town of Mirelle. Mirelle was famous for exactly one thing: its 47 glass clocks, each carved from a single block of blue ocean-glass by a reclusive horologist named Edran Vask. Unlike ordinary clocks, every glass clock in Mirelle ran **backwards**, counting down toward what the townspeople called the Stillday. Edran built the first clock in the year 1183 of the Marsh Calendar, and the last in 1221, shortly before he vanished.

The clocks were not synchronized. The fastest, mounted above the Bakery of Three Sisters, lost roughly eleven minutes every fortnight. The slowest, kept in the cellar of the mayor's house, had not moved in nineteen years. Children of Mirelle were taught a rhyme: *'Glass runs slow, glass runs fast, the truest hour is always last.'*

2. The Apprentice, Liorah Senn

Edran Vask took only one apprentice in his lifetime: a left-handed girl named Liorah Senn, who arrived in Mirelle at the age of fourteen carrying nothing but a copper compass and a jar of fireflies. Liorah had a rare condition the town doctor called 'tin-ear blindness' — she could not hear high-pitched sounds but could feel vibrations through her fingertips with extraordinary precision. This made her, oddly, the perfect clockmaker. She tuned each glass clock not by sound but by touch, pressing her palm against the casing until the trembling 'felt round,' as she put it.

Liorah discovered something Edran had hidden. Each of the 47 clocks contained a tiny engraved letter on the inside of its third gear. Read in the order the clocks were built, the 47 letters spelled a single sentence. She spent four years collecting them. The sentence read: **'The Stillday is not an ending but a door beneath the Bakery.'**

3. The Door Beneath the Bakery

On the night of the autumn flood in 1226, Liorah pried up the flagstones in the cellar of the Bakery of Three Sisters. Beneath them she found a brass hatch sealed with seven locks, each shaped like one of the town's clock faces. She had no keys. But she had her hands. By feeling the faint resonance each lock gave off when she hummed against it, she matched every lock to the exact clock whose vibration it echoed. The seventh and final lock matched the broken cellar clock — the one that had not moved in nineteen years.

Inside the hatch was not treasure but a room of mirrors, and at its center a single object: a clock made not of glass but of dark living wood, ticking **forwards**. Pinned beneath it was a note in Edran's hand, dated the very day he disappeared. It read: *'Liorah — if you are reading this, you found the round feeling. The glass clocks count down so that this one may count up. Wind it only when Mirelle is ready to remember.'*

4. What the Wooden Clock Remembered

Liorah wound the wooden clock three turns to the right, as Edran's note instructed. The mirrored room filled with images — not reflections of herself, but moving scenes of Mirelle's past: the great salt fire of 1190, the first bridge over the Quennar, and a young Edran burying something at the foot of the Tolbrach hills. The townspeople, it turned out, had a habit of forgetting their own history every generation, and the wooden clock was Edran's strange remedy — a machine that stored memory the way the glass clocks stored time.

Liorah became the second keeper of the clocks. She lived to the age of ninety-one and trained a deaf boy named Pell to feel the round feeling after her. To this day — so the story goes — the 47 glass clocks of Mirelle still run backwards, and somewhere beneath the Bakery of Three Sisters, one wooden clock quietly runs forward, remembering everything the town forgets.

Quick Facts (for testing your RAG)

Try asking your retrieval system these — the answers exist **only** in this document:

- Who carved the glass clocks, and how many were there? (Edran Vask; 47)
- What was Edran's apprentice named, and what was unusual about her? (Liorah Senn; left-handed, tin-ear blindness, tuned clocks by touch)
- What did the 47 engraved letters spell? ('The Stillday is not an ending but a door beneath the Bakery.')
- How many locks sealed the brass hatch, and how did Liorah open them? (Seven; by matching each lock's vibration to a clock)
- What was found inside the hatch? (A room of mirrors and a wooden clock that ticks forwards)
- Which direction and how many turns did Liorah wind the wooden clock? (Three turns to the right)
- Who did Liorah train as the next keeper? (A deaf boy named Pell)
- In what year did Edran build the first and last glass clock? (1183 and 1221, Marsh Calendar)